

Fakesters.

These are false identities that many people assume when online, often in the form of contemporary celebrities and stars, but also people can take photos of real people and steal their identities (especially with the widespread use of camera phones and in particular when reputations of people are valuable). Identity theft is even more difficult to monitor as most networking sites are not able to identify who is legitimate and who is not. In the past, Friendster has taken a dislike to these fakes as they have the potential to undermine real persons on networking sites. Friendster has attempted to eliminate all of these fake users by removing them from their sites and servers. This forced removal of accounts does not seem to follow the natural evolutionary process of sites that are emerging on the Internet at present. The culture that is emerging with social networking sites has yielded terms like “friendster”, “fakester”, “friendster whore”, “orkut-certified”, “orkut jail” and “tribe”, and these are very quickly emerging as new figures of speech in modern society and parlance.

Addiction

A lot of these sites are extremely addictive and it is quite easy to spend valuable time searching through the sites out of curiosity or from a voyeuristic point of view, especially on sites such as Tribe, orkut, Friendster and Ryze where there are galleries of persons to view and where the relationships are explicit. It is all too easy to browse and take an interest in persons that you see online, and to take a peek into their lives. This can create a sense of familiarity with people you do not know and this can be brought into the real world, as a sense of knowing that person online can make a person feel or believe that they know that person in the real world too. There is also the potential or danger in this of stalking people offline. However, is the virtual representation of humans in two dimensions likely to replace the real three dimensional models? It is unlikely, as there are only so many ways in which personalities can be represented online in these social sites. It is not really possible for these sites to represent the full human experience or model everything in the offline world, especially in the world of